

A Naval Gazette Entry for Lieutenant Otani Tsune (大谷恒)

A Note on the Investiture List of 11 September 1943
in the Naval Gazette (Internal Circulation Only), Extra Edition

Takuya Nemoto
Independent Researcher

Abstract

This note introduces and transcribes a single entry concerning Imperial Japanese Navy Lieutenant Otani Tsune (大谷恒) in the investiture list issued on 11 September 1943, preserved in the *Naval Gazette (Internal Circulation Only), Extra Edition* and made available by the Japan Center for Asian Historical Records (JACAR). The source establishes four facts: his rank at the time was Lieutenant (海軍大尉); he received the Order of the Sacred Treasure, Fourth Class; the order was issued on 11 September 1943; and his provisional entry number was 2603-25. It does not establish the reading of his name, his unit or posting, his dates of birth and death, or whether the decoration was conferred during his lifetime or posthumously. The aim here is deliberately narrow: to transcribe the entry accurately and to separate what the document supports from what it does not.

1. Introduction

Junior and mid-ranking officers of the Imperial Japanese Navy rarely left behind biographical documentation of their own. Information about individuals at this level survives mainly in scattered gazette entries, and the officer treated here is a case in point.

The purpose of this note is correspondingly limited. It transcribes one entry, fixes the bibliographic particulars that can be established from it, and states plainly what lies beyond the reach of the document. Biographical narrative and institutional analysis are deferred until further sources can be consulted.

2. The Source

The document is an issue of the *Naval Gazette (Internal Circulation Only), Extra Edition* (海軍公報(部内限)號外), for orders promulgated on 11 September 1943, held by the National Institute for Defense Studies, Ministry of Defense. It is available through JACAR under reference code C12070491000.⁽¹⁾

The item opens with the heading ○昭和十八年九月十一日發令 ("Promulgated 11 September 1943"). It first lists five recipients of the Third Order under the heading 敍勲三等授瑞寶章, bearing provisional entry numbers 2603-13 through 2603-17.⁽²⁾ A second heading, 敍勲四等授瑞寶章, then lists ten recipients of the Fourth Order, numbered 2603-18 through 2603-27. Otani appears in this second group.

3. Transcription

The Fourth Order section is transcribed below following the arrangement of the original.⁽³⁾ Traditional character forms are retained. In the rank column, 同 ("ditto") indicates repetition of the preceding entry.

敍勲四等授瑞寶章				
(通牒各)				
假記二六〇三一八	海軍大尉	小	西 敏 夫	
同 二六〇三一九	同	比	良 國 清	
同 二六〇三二〇	同	箱	山 徳太郎	
同 二六〇三二一	同	安	部 一 男	
同 二六〇三二二	同	増	田 利 章	
同 二六〇三二三	同	篠	田 不可止	
同 二六〇三二四	同	野	村 勇	
同 二六〇三二五	同	大	谷 恒	
(横須賀鎮守府關係)				
同 二六〇三二六	海軍中尉	石	井 丑 松	
同 二六〇三二七	同	細	田 義 男	

The entry for Otani therefore reads: provisional entry number 2603-25, rank as above (Lieutenant), name 大谷恒. A further group of entries (2603-30 onward) appears below a ruled division on the same image; it constitutes a separate item and is not treated here.

4. What the Source Establishes

Four points can be stated with confidence.

- (1) Otani's rank at the time was Lieutenant (海軍大尉). His rank column reads 同, but the Fourth Order list opens at 2603-18 (Konishi Toshio) with 海軍大尉, and every intervening line carries the ditto mark, so the rank carries through to Otani.
- (2) The decoration is the Order of the Sacred Treasure, Fourth Class.
- (3) The order was promulgated on 11 September 1943.
- (4) His provisional entry number is 2603-25.

On the arrangement of the list, Otani stands before the subheading (横須賀鎮守府關係), "Yokosuka Naval District, related personnel." He therefore belongs to a group distinct from Ishii Ushimatsu and Hosoda Yoshio, who follow that subheading.⁽⁴⁾ No subheading identifying the group to which Otani belongs appears within the portion of the document examined here.

5. What the Source Does Not Establish

Given the nature of the document, the following remain undetermined, and the limits should be stated explicitly.

- (1) The reading of the name. 大谷 may be read Otani or Oya, and 恒 may be read Tsune or Hisashi, among other possibilities. The gazette supplies no phonetic gloss, so the reading cannot be settled from this source. The form "Otani Tsune" is used here for convenience only.
- (2) Unit or shipboard posting. The list gives rank and name alone, with no indication of assignment.
- (3) Date of commission and dates of birth and death.
- (4) Whether the decoration was conferred during his lifetime or posthumously. Suggestive evidence is discussed below, but it falls short of proof.

6. Observations

On the provisional entry numbers: those appearing in this item run consecutively from 2603-13 to 2603-27, and the leading four digits, 2603, correspond to the year 2603 in the imperial calendar, that is, 1943. A running number prefixed by the year is the likely explanation, though a single item cannot establish the practice.

On the possibility of posthumous conferral: the entry for Otani carries no 故 ("the late"), a prefix used in naval gazette investiture lists to mark recipients who had died. Its absence points toward conferral during his lifetime. How consistently that convention was applied at this date cannot be determined from a single item, however, and no firm conclusion is drawn here.

On the standing of the decoration: the Order of the Sacred Treasure is generally understood to have recognized service in office rather than battlefield distinction. Situating this particular award within contemporary criteria would require systematic examination of the relevant honors legislation together with comparable investiture lists from the same period, which lies outside the scope of this note.

7. Conclusion

What has been established amounts to a single sentence: Otani Tsune was a naval lieutenant who received the Order of the Sacred Treasure, Fourth Class, on 11 September 1943. For a figure about whom nothing else is presently known, however, fixing rank, decoration, date, and entry number against the document provides a defined starting point for further work.

Three lines of inquiry follow directly. First, tracing his commission and postings through the naval appointment gazettes and officer registers. Second, confirming his dates and the reading of his name from service records. Third, comparing the other recipients named in the same promulgation in order to reconstruct the organizing principle of the list. Only after that work can an officer of this rank be placed meaningfully within the personnel machinery of the wartime navy.

Notes

- (1) *Naval Gazette (Internal Circulation Only), Extra Edition*, orders promulgated 11 September 1943, Fourth Order, Order of the Sacred Treasure, provisional entry no. 2603-25. National Institute for Defense Studies, Ministry of Defense. JACAR (Japan Center for Asian Historical Records) Ref. C12070491000.
- (2) *Ibid.*, Third Order, Order of the Sacred Treasure, provisional entry nos. 2603-13 to 2603-17.
- (3) The transcription is based on visual inspection of the image published by JACAR. Where the condition of the printing admits of more than one reading, this is indicated in the text.
- (4) *Ibid.*, provisional entry nos. 2603-26 and 2603-27, placed beneath the subheading 横須賀鎮守府關係.

AI Use Disclosure

Claude, a large language model developed by Anthropic, was used in planning the structure of this note and in editing its prose. The selection of the source, the verification of the transcription, and all judgments as to the substance of the argument were made by the author, who bears sole responsibility for the content.